PROJECT SYNDICATE DIGEST

October 2026

Compiled collection of all curated commentaries and analysis columns.

Generated automatically on 10/28/2026
Total Articles: 96

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1. America’s Looming Debt Reckoning

Author: Kenneth Rogoff **Published:** Oct 1, 2026 **Link:** View Original

CAMBRIDGE—America’s fiscal position is increasingly looking like a train hurtling along a twisting mountain track. No one seems willing to slow down for fear of falling behind schedule and losing their job. Even if the train doesn’t crash, it is worth asking: Why keep pushing it? Despite solid growth, the federal deficit is about 6% of GDP. Yet the option of slowing down does not appear to be in President Donald Trump’s playbook.

2. Putin Is Testing NATO at Ukraine’s Borders

Author: Anna Husarska **Published:** Oct 1, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LVIV—Jet-powered Russian drones recently hit a train in Ukraine a mere mile from the Polish border. The drone pilots, and their Kremlin minders, must have known that officials from Europe, the United Kingdom, the United States, and elsewhere had previously left Kyiv by train after participating in the Yalta European Strategy (YES) Annual Meeting, a sort of Ukrainian Davos. But the trains carrying former UK Prime Minister Boris Johnson, former Swedish Prime Minister Carl Bildt, former CIA Director David Petraeus, and former Polish President Aleksander Kwaśniewski, among others, were not hit. Had the Russians missed them intentionally or through incompetence?

3. The OECD Should Be Reclaimed, Not Abandoned

Author: Kim Ruhl **Published:** Oct 1, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—On September 30, the OECD marked the 65th anniversary of its founding. Like many other aging international organizations, it has developed a taste for mission creep, as we witnessed firsthand as former delegates there. That is why some US policymakers want to reduce or eliminate funding for the organization. But walking away from the OECD would mean abandoning capabilities that are becoming ever more important in America’s economic competition with China.

4. The Sovereign Wealth Fund America Needs

Author: Steven Hill **Published:** Oct 1, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LOS ANGELES/NEW BRUNSWICK—OpenAI’s Sam Altman, US President Donald Trump, US Senator Bernie Sanders, and California Governor Gavin Newsom do not agree on much, yet they have all proposed that the United States create a sovereign wealth fund (SWF), seeded by stocks from AI companies, to cope with AI’s negative impacts. It is a good idea. Unfortunately, their proposals are woefully inadequate.

5. The Hard Road to a Middle-Power Order

Author: Sophie Eisentraut **Published:** Oct 1, 2026 **Link:** View Original

MUNICH—In his historic speech in Davos in January, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney urged middle powers to confront an increasingly harsh geopolitical reality by joining forces to forge a “third path” between kowtowing to great-power pressure and going it alone. But when it came to defining this path, Carney’s speech outlined two projects of very different scope.

6. Closing Europe’s Dynamism Deficit

Author: Carl Benedikt Frey **Published:** Oct 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

OXFORD—Technology has always been a source of power. During the centuries when China sat near the world’s frontier of invention, it was also a master of statecraft. But with the Industrial Revolution in Europe, the decisive technologies of steam, steel, railways, and rifled artillery shifted the balance of power westward, inaugurating a period embedded in China’s collective memory as the “century of humiliation.”

7. Why Is the Global Economy So Resilient?

Author: Nouriel Roubini **Published:** Oct 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—Despite the rising risks, uncertainties, and large negative supply shocks of the last two years, stock markets and the overall global economy have held up quite well. Following the shock of US President Donald Trump's "Liberation Day" (April 2) tariffs in 2025 came this year's Iran War, which caused the largest energy shock since the oil crises of the 1970s.

8. Global AI Oversight Now

Author: Gabriela Ramos **Published:** Oct 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

PARIS—Several years ago, Mariana Mazzucato and I asked a simple question: Who is in charge if something goes wrong in the AI world? The question remains unanswered, even after the United Nations Security Council met last week to discuss the existential risks posed by AI.

9. Trump’s Great Oil Heist

Author: Cristina Ramirez **Published:** Oct 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—When the United States ousted Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro earlier this year and put him in a New York jail cell, Venezuelans at home and abroad rejoiced. For the first time in 27 years, the country faced a real possibility of regime change. But removing an autocrat does not necessarily dismantle the authoritarian system that kept him in power, particularly when the man who removed him is an aspiring authoritarian and kleptocrat in his own right.

10. Conserving a Connected Ocean

Author: Marie-May Jeremie **Published:** Oct 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

VICTORIA—Every year, sea turtles return to the beaches of northern KwaZulu-Natal, in South Africa, where they began life. Once they leave the shore, some travel north through the Mozambique Channel, using waters and coastal habitats off Mozambique and Madagascar, while others journey into the wider Indian Ocean. South Africa can protect their nesting beaches, but no country alone can protect their entire journey.

Governments have abandoned many of the economic ideas blamed for the populist backlash, yet support for populist parties continues to grow. This puzzle lies at the heart of two new books, both of which suggest that liberalism’s decline may outlast the economic forces that set it in motion.

While empirical inquiry has its place in economics, the pursuit of causality must not be allowed to displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested.

The turtle embodies the central challenge of ocean conservation. Strong national action is indispensable, but protecting migratory species, interconnected habitats, and shared ecosystems requires countries to work together. And to do that, the finance supporting such cooperation must be capable of making the same journey as the turtle.

For the approximately 60 million people living within 100 kilometers (62 miles) of the Western Indian Ocean coastline, the stakes of conservation are immediate. Healthy marine ecosystems support food security, livelihoods, trade, and tourism, as well as providing bulwarks against storms. They are the natural foundation of the sustainable blue economies our countries are working to build.

But their value also reaches far beyond the region. Our mangroves and seagrasses store carbon. Our reefs sustain biodiversity. And our waters support migratory species whose journeys connect coastlines and the wider ocean. Protecting them may be a regional responsibility, but it is also in the rest of the world’s interest.

Regional leaders do not lack ambition, nor are we waiting for others to define what ocean conservation should look like. In my country, Seychelles, we have seen what can happen when ambitious goals are backed by strong political commitments and innovative finance. Our marine spatial planning and conservation-finance experience demonstrates that protecting the ocean can be integrated into national development. Now, other countries across the Western Indian Ocean are pursuing similar strategies shaped by their own priorities and circumstances.

Through the Nairobi Convention, governments have committed to stronger cooperation in developing sustainable blue economies and more effective, inclusive forms of ocean governance. The Regional Ocean Governance Strategy has established the mandate, and we are all now tasked with creating the financing mechanisms capable of delivering it.

AI-generated content already accounts for half the articles published online, and not even digital forensics experts can tell what’s real anymore. Can those still offering a humanistic vision of online life make themselves heard over the din?

It is a tall order. Achieving the common objective of protecting 30% of marine and coastal areas by 2030 requires more than drawing boundaries on a map. Protected areas must be supported by science, effective management, enforcement, community participation, and investments in sustainable livelihoods.

With the landmark Agreement on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction now in force, new possibilities are opening for conservation beyond national waters. The Western Indian Ocean region must be ready to influence how the agreement is implemented. Our responsibilities will extend far beyond any single project or grant. Reefs do not recover according to project deadlines, just as fisheries won't be replenished in sync with funding cycles. Conservation requires continuity.

That is why women from three coastal villages in Anjouan, Comoros, formed an association after learning from fishing communities in Madagascar and Zanzibar. They temporarily closed part of their reef to octopus fishing, helped enforce the closure, and then waited. When the fishing ground reopened, the average octopus caught was twice its previous weight. The idea crossed borders because likeminded communities were open to learning from one another.

In these and other ways, Western Indian Ocean communities are already taking the lead on conservation. But sustaining and extending their progress requires finance that supports local leadership, knowledge-sharing, and long-term ecosystem management. National institutions and project investments remain essential, but some responsibilities are regional by nature. Fisheries can move and species can migrate between interconnected habitats.

No single fund can finance every item on the conservation agenda. Pollution controls, greener ports, and other maritime priorities require different instruments. Nonetheless, governments are working toward a Western Indian Ocean Regional Conservation Trust Fund (RCTF) that can fill critical gaps, mobilizing and deploying sustained finance for priorities that cross borders and are best addressed regionally. Designed to complement and not compete with national funds, development banks, and project finance, the RCTF will focus only where cross-border cooperation adds clear value.

The region is not starting from scratch on this issue. Consultations with governments, conservation organizations, and financial partners are already ongoing, informed by lessons from near and far. But the next phase must be government-led to determine the RCTF's priorities, safeguards, governance structure, and relationship with existing institutions.

International partners can help accelerate that work. They are not being asked to create a new agenda or finance another isolated project. They can help build one component of a regionally owned financing architecture, directed toward conservation needs that conventional funding struggles to sustain. This is not simply about funding conservation in the Western Indian Ocean. The real opportunity is to invest in the region's own capacity to lead the effort.

When governments meet for the Twelfth Conference of the Parties to the Nairobi Convention (COP12) next week, they will mark 40 years of cooperation through that agreement. They must also look ahead. A sustainable blue economy for the region must be built on healthy ecosystems backed by reliable, long-term finance. The goal for the conference should be to authorize a government-led next phase for the RCTF, defining where it can add value and how it should cooperate with other regional bodies.

The Western Indian Ocean is one connected system. Its future demands finance equal to the distance its species travel, the connections its ecosystems sustain, and the ambition its countries are bringing to the table.

11. Climate Resilience Starts With Care

Author: Caren Grown **Published:** Oct 2, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—It is getting harder by the day to justify the slow pace of adaptation to climate change. Last year was one of the hottest on record, with economies and communities around the world disrupted by extreme heat, heavy rainfall, and tropical cyclones. As November's United Nations Climate Change Conference (COP31) in Turkey approaches, governments must move beyond climate commitments and focus on implementation.

Governments have abandoned many of the economic ideas blamed for the populist backlash, yet support for populist parties continues to grow. This puzzle lies at the heart of two new books, both of which suggest that liberalism's decline may outlast the economic forces that set it in motion.

While empirical inquiry has its place in economics, the pursuit of causality must not be allowed to displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested.

Financing for adaptation activities remains nowhere near what is needed. The UN Environment Programme estimates that developing countries will need $310–365 billion per year through 2035, putting the current funding gap at $280 billion. Getting the money to where it can do the most good may be an even bigger challenge, as institutions struggle to identify adaptation investments that are ready to implement and whose risks can be properly assessed and priced.

In a new working paper, we argue that estimates of funding needs and proposed investment pipelines overlook a critical piece of infrastructure: an ecosystem of climate-adapted care services that helps families prepare for, cope with, and recover from climate-induced hazards. Properly designed, these services can bolster household and community resilience. The same principle underpins investments in early-warning systems and adaptive social protections designed to help countries respond to climate shocks.

Provisional estimates suggest that at least 35,000 excess deaths occurred across Europe during this summer's severe back-to-back heat waves. Despite their well-developed welfare systems, the absence of climate-adapted physical infrastructure and coordinated services contributed to this excess mortality.

Yet national climate-adaptation plans rarely account for what happens when care breaks down. Floods and wildfires displace families and separate caregivers from the people who depend on them. When household-based care is no longer possible, formal care can become a lifeline for older people and people with disabilities who cannot evacuate or manage on their own. Without reliable care services, health issues can lead to otherwise preventable hospital admissions, putting even more pressure on already strained services.

As matters stand, family caregivers are left to shoulder the burden, facing injury and burnout during prolonged emergencies. Some, most of them women, are forced to leave paid work just when their families can least afford to lose income. When care systems fail, a climate shock can quickly become both a health and economic crisis. Strong care systems can prevent these cascading failures, making care a crucial part of climate resilience.

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Leaving care out of national adaptation plans thus means underestimating what climate resilience actually requires. Admittedly, anticipating those needs is difficult, as there is no standard definition of what qualifies as adaptation, and

national estimates are often based on individual projects, most of them in conventional sectors.

That sector-by-sector approach allows care to fall through the cracks. Agriculture, forestry, fishing, water supply, and sanitation account for nearly 40% of global adaptation finance, while health receives an estimated 4–6% and education around 2%. Long-term care and early-childhood care and education are essentially absent, particularly in low- and middle-income countries, where most care is provided informally.

Despite being too low, the $310–365 billion figure is already baked into national plans and multilateral-development-bank targets. But as climate shocks intensify, people will need more care, not less. And when formal services fall short, unpaid caregivers—overwhelmingly women and girls—will end up filling the gap.

Our paper proposes a way to begin correcting that omission. For example, we estimate that building climate-resilient care infrastructure in Bangladesh would require an investment equivalent to roughly 3–5% of GDP, similar to what is needed for health and education. This is a substantial investment, but only a fraction of the estimated value of unpaid care work.

Building that care infrastructure would require millions of workers. We estimate that early-childhood care and education and long-term care could directly employ 3.6–7 million people in Bangladesh. More jobs would come from providing food and other supplies, as well as from building or retrofitting childcare facilities and homes for people receiving long-term care.

Care services also give financiers a concrete way to put adaptation money to work. For starters, such investments come with an established evidence base—data on unit costs, staffing models, utilization, and outcomes—facilitating risk assessment. Some of these investments partially pay for themselves through tax revenue from higher employment and lower future spending on health and social protection. And demand is demographically guaranteed, since the need for care can only grow as populations age.

As adaptation financing tightens, every dollar has to work harder. That makes it all the more important to invest in care systems that help communities withstand climate shocks while easing pressure on public budgets.

12. Is Russia’s Placement on the Security Council Legal?

Author: Denys Shtilierman **Published:** Oct 5, 2026 **Link:** View Original

KYIV—“We the peoples of the United Nations determined to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war.” So begins the UN Charter. Yet Russia’s war of aggression against Ukraine is well into its fourth year, confirming just how far the UN has strayed from its foundational promise.

13. To Support Nepal, Waive Remittance Fees

Author: Ngozi Okonjo-Iweala **Published:** Oct 5, 2026 **Link:** View Original

GENEVA—The flash floods that struck Nepal on August 26 claimed more than a thousand lives and destroyed livelihoods, homes, farms, and public infrastructure. With reconstruction and the economic recovery now underway, support for the survivors can travel fastest through payment networks and family ties—as is usually the case when disasters strike developing countries.

14. What a Canada–Europe Alliance Needs

Author: Bertrand Badré **Published:** Oct 5, 2026 **Link:** View Original

PARIS—In today’s world, any new partnership between democratic societies will be stronger if ordinary citizens, civil-society groups, businesses, universities, the media, and local communities play a meaningful role in shaping it. That is certainly true of the Canada–Europe relationship as it enters a new phase.

15. Iran’s Moment of Opportunity

Author: Abdullah Gül **Published:** Oct 5, 2026 **Link:** View Original

ISTANBUL—On February 28, the United States and Israel shocked the world by launching strikes across Iran and assassinating the country’s supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. Civilian casualties quickly mounted, including 150 civilians—mostly children—killed when American missiles struck an elementary school. Iran duly retaliated by targeting Israel and US bases across the region and throttling maritime transit through the Strait of Hormuz.

16. Brazil’s Voters Have Moved

Author: Robert Muggah **Published:** Oct 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BERLIN—Brazilians awoke on Monday to a changed political map. Flávio Bolsonaro, the son of former Brazilian President Jair Bolsonaro, who is now under house arrest for attempting to overturn the last presidential election, has received 47% of the vote in the first round of this year’s presidential election, while the incumbent, Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, received 45%. Brazil appears poised to join the growing ranks of rightward-veering countries.

17. Brazil’s Election Debacle Is Lula’s Fault

Author: Andrés Velasco **Published:** Oct 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

SANTIAGO—Brazilian President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva once had a credible claim to be the savior of the country’s left. After the October 4 general election, he looks more like the left’s gravedigger.

18. Sino-American Stability Without Trust

Author: Minghao Zhao **Published:** Oct 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BEIJING—At the recent summit between US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping, China’s primary objective was to prevent tensions from escalating further. From that perspective, it was largely successful.

19. Why the US-China Trade Truce Matters

Author: Shang-Jin Wei **Published:** Oct 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—Chinese President Xi Jinping’s state visit to Washington in September produced no major new agreement. But it did result in an extension of the trade truce that Xi and US President Donald Trump struck in Busan, South Korea, last October. Instead of expiring on November 10, the truce will expire on January 10, 2027. Though modest, this achievement has given an unstable world economy a reprieve.

20. Does Inclusive Finance Really Need Stablecoins?

Author: Michael Wiegand **Published:** Oct 6, 2026 **Link:** View Original

SEATTLE—Much progress has been made on financial inclusion over the last 15 years, with account ownership in low- and middle-income countries surging from 42% in 2011 to 75% today. This largely reflects the rise of new banking models, such as mobile money, which have lowered both costs and technological barriers substantially, especially by enabling people to access their accounts using basic mobile phones. But 1.3 billion adults—more than half of them women—remain excluded from the formal financial system, and lower-income consumers still struggle to find and access the financial products and services they need.

While empirical inquiry has its place in economics, the pursuit of causality must not be allowed to displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested.

Stablecoins are being touted as the technology that will finally bring the world's unbanked poor into the financial system. But the hype is unwarranted.

Everyday domestic payments are the cornerstone of financial inclusion, and money and bank accounts linked through an inclusive instant payment system are clearly superior to stablecoins for this purpose. Both options offer 24-hour access and instant low-cost financial transfers. But traditional accounts can be accessed through regular phones using simple messages, whereas stablecoins require a smartphone or internet-connected computer, not to mention a much higher level of digital literacy. For a woman farmer in northern Kenya, who has a basic phone and no data connection, stablecoins are no solution.

Data support this assertion, showing that the vast majority of stablecoin transactions are limited to uses like cryptocurrency purchases. Even where governments have pushed hard to launch their own digital currencies, such as in China and Nigeria, there has been little uptake, because people see no advantage in adopting them. For some, digital currencies might even represent a disadvantage: stablecoins transmit risk from payer to payee in a way that instant payment systems do not, partly because their value on traded markets can differ from their face value.

Some argue that stablecoins are better for cross-border payments. They point out that remittances sent in the form of a dollar-backed stablecoin could reach, say, Kampala from anywhere else in the world in seconds and at low cost. But the recipient would still need to convert the stablecoin into Ugandan shillings, and the market for doing so is a fraction of the size of the market banks and money-transfer operators draw on, with worse exchange rates. As a result, money-transfer operators like Wise or Remitly generally offer better value end-to-end; they are certainly easier to access for most low-income recipients.

Cross-border bank transfers are still slower and more expensive than such operators (and stablecoins), but this can be addressed by linking domestic instant-payment systems, as envisioned in the G20 Roadmap for Cross-Border Payments. This approach is already being implemented in some regions: the Nexus payment system, for example, links India, Malaysia, the Philippines, Singapore, and Thailand.

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Of course, financial inclusion entails more than just payments. Financial systems must offer all consumers a range of products that meet their needs. Fortunately, we may well be on the verge of an explosion in new financial products for

low-income customers. The key ingredient is data: critical information about an individual (shared with their consent) can increasingly be used to build tailored financial products.

This approach is already beginning to transform lives. In Ethiopia, a regulatory reform on data exchange enabled the Cooperative Bank of Oromia to launch a lending product called Michu, built not on collateral but on transaction data, and tailored to the borrower's specific needs. Within a year, Michu had built a customer base that was more than one-third women.

For farmers—who typically do not have extensive transaction histories, since most agriculture payments are still made with cash—different types of data could be used. Governments already increasingly collect data on the land farmers hold, the crops they grow, and even the rainfall on their fields (verified via satellites), primarily to provide advice. Shared with consent, such data could enable a lender not only to estimate farmers' current income accurately, but also to structure loan-repayments to match their cash-flow cycle.

Lenders could even use these data and advice models to identify opportunities for individual farmers to increase their incomes, such as by installing solar-irrigation pumps. Linking lending to such opportunities would lower the price of the loan, reduce the risk to the lender, and add extra value for the farmer. The same data could be used to price insurance that pays out the moment satellite imagery confirms a drought, instead of waiting for a claims adjuster. It is early days, but initiatives along these lines in Ethiopia and Kenya offer reason to hope that this approach can deliver the financial products farmers need. Ethiopia's National Agri-Finance Implementation Roadmap (NAFIR), launched jointly by the National Bank of Ethiopia and the Ministry of Agriculture, will provide lenders with a wide range of data from the OpenAgriNet system, structured in a way to be useful to lenders.

Ultimately, what increasing financial inclusion requires does not involve stablecoins. Policymakers must develop interoperable payment infrastructure to enable banks, mobile-money providers, and fintech firms to exchange money freely, domestically and across borders. Funders should support the strengthening of regulatory capacity and data infrastructure—less glamorous than launching a stablecoin pilot, but far more impactful. And financial institutions should leverage new data to design financial products for low-income people's needs and opportunities, rather than what they own or their past transactions.

Future progress on financial inclusion will not be decided by which digital currency wins. It will be decided by whether the financial system is sufficiently open, competitive, and interconnected.

21. With AI, Sharing Is Caring

Author: Jeff Jarvis **Published:** Oct 7, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—Who wants ignorant AI? Wrong AI? Stupid AI? If privacy and copyright advocates, regulators, and crusaders against the technology succeed in cutting off or poisoning AI's sources of reliable data and authoritative information, won't bad AI be the result?

22. Closing NATO’s Deterrence Gap

Author: Agnia Grigas **Published:** Oct 7, 2026 **Link:** View Original

VILNIUS—On September 23, just a week after NATO aircraft shot down a drone that had entered Lithuanian air space from Belarus, a Russian military helicopter flying out of Kaliningrad briefly breached Polish airspace. Neither intrusion was an isolated episode. A growing catalogue of security incidents shows that the Kremlin’s war of aggression against Ukraine is pressing ever more ominously on NATO’s borders.

23. How Africa Can Leverage the US-China Thaw

Author: Prasad Ananthakrishnan **Published:** Oct 7, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—Chinese President Xi Jinping's state visit to the US produced a two-month extension of the current bilateral trade truce—and little else. Nonetheless, both leaders signaled that they want a more stable relationship ahead of the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation summit in Shenzhen in November and the G20 in Miami in December. This creates an opportunity for emerging and developing economies in Africa and elsewhere.

24. The India-Pakistan Cold War

Author: Shashi Tharoor **Published:** Oct 7, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW DELHI—For decades, South Asia was locked in a perpetual cycle of conflict management: brief military clashes between India and Pakistan would be followed by de-escalation and the resumption of formal peace talks, which eventually gave way to another bout of conflict. But this pattern has now been broken. No high-level dialogue has taken place since 2016. Rather than some temporary diplomatic tantrum, this reflects a paradigm shift in Indian foreign policy, permanently altering the subcontinent’s security architecture.

25. The Next Era of Reform Must Be About Capability

Author: Pepukaye Bardouille **Published:** Oct 7, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BRIDGETOWN—We tend to think of a country's assets in terms of natural resources, technology, and capital. But equally important is its ability to shape its own future, as opposed to having its development determined mainly by external factors.

While empirical inquiry has its place in economics, the pursuit of causality must not be allowed to displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested.

Major global stressors in recent years have brought this reality into sharper focus. COVID-19, rising interest rates, energy-price spikes, and an intensifying climate crisis have forced many small states into perpetual firefighting mode. For the most indebted and least diversified economies, each new upheaval has pushed aside years of planning, leading to calls for higher investment in resilience. And yet resilience alone is not enough, because a country can do everything right and still end up worse off if it lacks genuine agency.

The true test of development is whether it expands a country's choices and capabilities. It is this insight that lies behind the Barbados-led Bridgetown Initiative, which seeks to create a more responsive financial system, unlock affordable long-term finance, and develop better tools for managing shocks. That is what countries need to maintain their national goals when crises erupt.

Small states understand this all too well. For them, uncertainty is not an occasional problem, but a persistent condition. They were thinking about disaster preparedness and strategic autonomy long before these topics became regular items on the international agenda. The challenge was never to eliminate vulnerability entirely, but to preserve freedom of action despite it. In a world of rising geopolitical tensions and climate risk, agency proved to be one of the most valuable assets a country could possess.

The current era of development reform proposals understandably focuses on expanding the fiscal and policy space needed to help countries weather crises. However, what ultimately matters is whether investments leave behind stronger institutions, deeper expertise, more competitive firms, and a greater capacity to solve complex problems.

Though the international system has become more effective at financing projects—from roads and energy systems to hospitals and digital infrastructure—development cannot be reduced to a series of investments or line items on a balance sheet. The harder task is building up the means to design, deliver, maintain, and expand those investments.

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Such know-how is not limited to infrastructure. Consider Barbados's experience with sovereign-debt restructuring, debt-pause clauses, and debt-for-resilience transactions. None of these innovations emerged by accident. They required discipline in economic management over an extended period, political leaders who were willing to back negotiating teams through years of difficult, unglamorous work, and policymakers who developed their expertise by tackling problems for which there were no clear precedents.

The same lesson applies across the wider economy. Barbados is now seeking to build on a decade of climate-finance leadership while advancing ambitious food-security, social-protection, and energy-independence initiatives at home. We

understand that scaling up battery-storage capacity and pursuing the country's first utility-scale wind project require far more than technical plans. These investments demand coordination among ministries, regulators, the private sector, financiers, and neighboring communities. Success depends on bringing all these players together to work through disputes, structure viable deals, and keep projects moving when obstacles arise.

Barbados's own recent experiences point to a broader truth about how expertise is built. People learn by doing, and institutions, by extension, learn through the people who build and sustain them. Capacity is forged through negotiating difficult deals, delivering projects, managing crises, learning from mistakes, and taking on progressively more complex responsibilities. Technical skills matter, but so do incentives, trust, continuity, the authority to act, and the time to think and experiment.

Likewise, developing countries need firms capable of competing internationally, adopting new technologies, and responding to changing markets. Development succeeds when the public and private sectors strengthen each other.

No country develops these capabilities overnight. They are acquired through repeated exposure to difficult situations. Barbados recently lost its Chief Fisheries Officer, and her passing is still felt across the sector she helped transform. She knew almost every fisher by name, introduced technologies that modernized the fleet, and earned the trust of a community that was struggling to attract younger talent. Her contributions were not just technical. She also brought decades of accumulated knowledge, relationships, judgment, and credibility.

That is often how institutional memory works in small states. Expertise resides in people before it becomes embedded in systems, and if key individuals depart or pass away, a country's entire development agenda can be set back. In addition to cultivating talent, developing countries also must ensure that knowledge, relationships, and experience become institutional assets rather than individual ones.

The same principle applies to external support. Development partnerships are most effective when they strengthen a country's ability to deliver results for itself. Governments cannot treat institutional strength merely as a by-product of reform. They must make it a strategic objective, embedded in organizations capable of maintaining continuity through political cycles and personnel changes.

Of course, emphasizing capabilities does not diminish the importance of affordable finance, access to technology, or a trading system that enables resource-rich countries not only to export raw materials, but also to process, manufacture, and innovate, thereby creating jobs, developing skills, and retaining more value domestically. Agency cannot be separated from the broader system in which it is exercised, and significant structural constraints remain.

But at a time when the global agenda is increasingly defined by a steady cycle of conferences, summits, communiqués, and new initiatives, it is worth stepping back to ask a harder question: Are countries actually becoming better able to make decisions, deliver results, and determine their own path?

The next generation of development reform should not be measured solely by how much finance is mobilized or how much fiscal space is created. It must also be judged by the extent to which countries emerge better able to set their own priorities, respond to challenges, and seize opportunities. The true measure of success is whether countries are gaining the capacity and confidence to shape events, rather than be shaped by them.

26. The World Has Passed Peak Trump

Author: Ian Bremmer **Published:** Oct 8, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—At the UN General Assembly last month, US President Donald Trump delivered a victory speech. A decade after telling his supporters that he'd stack so many victories that "you may even get tired of winning," he offered a list of successes, including the settlement of eight wars, action against "the bully of the Middle East" in Iran, a deal with Denmark on Greenland, and the arrest of Venezuela's "outlaw dictator," Nicolás Maduro.

27. Europe’s Place in the Global Redivision of Labor

Author: Daniel Gros **Published:** Oct 8, 2026 **Link:** View Original

MILAN—The world’s three largest continent-sized economies are moving in different directions. Each has its own strengths and weaknesses, though the balance appears to be more favorable in the United States and China than in Europe.

28. MAGA’s Self-Destructive Culture War

Author: Ian Buruma **Published:** Oct 8, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—There are many reasons why then-US Vice President and Democratic nominee Kamala Harris lost the US presidential election to Donald Trump two years ago. Her campaign started too late. She inherited a great deal of anger against US President Joe Biden. And Trump is a gifted demagogue, who knows how to exploit fear-driven rage and hostility.

29. How to Break the German Malaise

Author: Helmut K. Anheier **Published:** Oct 8, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BERLIN—Not so long ago, Germany seemed like it could do no wrong, thanks to its strong economy, excellent infrastructure, and stable political system. Yet now it seems as though Germany can do nothing right. With a sluggish economy and crumbling infrastructure, it is falling behind technologically and succumbing to extremist political parties.

30. Global Financial Reform that Centers African Women

Author: Crystal Simeoni **Published:** Oct 8, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NAIROBI—Over the past two decades, feminist economists have scored several policy wins at the national level, ranging from gender-responsive budgets to increased investment in care infrastructure. But change at the international level remains stubbornly slow. The global financial architecture continues to generate policies that depend on women's labor without accounting for it.

While empirical inquiry has its place in economics, the pursuit of causality must not be allowed to displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested.

The International Monetary Fund–World Bank Annual Meetings in Bangkok this month offer an opportunity for policymakers to accelerate that change. More specifically, the first annual cycle of the newly launched Borrowers' Platform will enable developing countries to share knowledge, exchange experiences, and speak collectively in debt discussions.

This forum is particularly important for African countries, where average spending on interest payments is $70 per capita, compared with $60 on education and $39 on health. Every austerity measure prescribed by a sovereign-debt restructuring determines the extent to which public services will be squeezed—and how much women will have to pick up the slack. In Kenya, a country that remains stuck in a debt trap, women spend, on average, three hours and thirty-seven minutes more than men on unpaid domestic and care work every day.

The negotiations for a United Nations Framework Convention on International Tax Cooperation provide a similar opening. This effort to rewrite the global rules so that profits are taxed where economic activity occurs could help address capital flight from Africa, estimated at $88.6 billion annually and driven partly by tax evasion. The outcome of the negotiations will determine how much African governments have left over for clinics, schools, and water systems, and how much will be relegated to social reproduction—the unpaid or underpaid work, done most often by women and girls, that sustains life and makes all economic activity possible.

To be sure, women's rights are often overlooked in times of upheaval. Gender equality was first on the chopping block when donor governments tightened their foreign-aid budgets, and feminist foreign policies were quietly shelved when they became inconvenient. Now the UN is weighing whether to fold UN Women and the UN Population Fund into one entity in a bid for "efficiency" precisely when those institutions are most needed.

But it is possible to rebuild global economic governance with a feminist approach. Negotiators for the UN Tax Convention should consider where social reproduction occurs, not just where multinationals are based, and allocate resources accordingly. As for the IMF, the debt restructuring process must be overhauled to assess not only whether a government can service its obligations, but also what these payments will cost in public services and women's time.

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The latter requires measuring and valuing social reproduction. Kenya found that, in 2021, women accounted for 25.8 billion hours out of a total 30.6 billion hours of unpaid domestic and care work, which the Kenya National Bureau of

Statistics estimated was equivalent to 23.1% of GDP. Using these data, Kenya has since developed a National Care Policy aimed at integrating care planning into national and county budgets. In 2025, Mauritius showed how to translate this awareness into fiscal policy by zero-rating VAT on infant food and staple vegetables. The IMF could make social reproduction visible at the international level by incorporating national household satellite accounts into Article IV consultations, its regular economic assessments of member countries.

African countries are leading the way on this front, and the multilateral financial architecture must support, not impede, their efforts. As the late development economist Thandika Mkandawire spent much of his career arguing, African governments were never short on policy ideas. But they were denied the space to do their own theorizing; instead, they were saddled with the theories underpinning stringent loan conditions.

The African Union’s Common African Position on Debt (CAP), adopted in February, is an attempt to conceptualize a new approach. It calls for a binding UN Framework Convention on Sovereign Debt—the hoped-for structural overhaul that did not materialize at last year’s Fourth International Conference on Financing for Development—and restructuring processes that are transparent, debtor-inclusive, and no longer driven solely by creditor interests. The Borrowers’ Platform may be a voluntary coordination mechanism rather than a binding negotiating body, but that is all the more reason to advocate the CAP at the Annual Meetings.

Members of the Borrowers’ Platform should propose two concrete policy changes. First, the IMF must reform its debt-sustainability analysis, the framework it uses to determine how much debt a country can afford to service, to incorporate what repayment costs in social reproduction. This would allow African governments to shield public services from cuts. Otherwise, more countries may end up like Kenya: the National Treasury reports that 51.8% of tax revenue in the last fiscal year went to debt and pension payments, leaving hardly any funds for the social programs that reduce women’s unpaid work. Second, when negotiating debt-restructuring deals, every IMF program tied to a debt restructuring must include a binding floor on spending for health, water, and care infrastructure, replacing the soft, often-missed social spending targets the Fund uses today.

What may seem like technical adjustments are actually the first steps toward creating a debt architecture that will deliver for the women of Africa. Writing about the pandemic, the novelist Arundhati Roy argued that rupture offers “a chance to rethink the doomsday machine we have built for ourselves.” The multilateral system is undergoing its own rupture now. The task ahead is to ensure that the women of Africa are not a footnote to the system, but rather central to what comes next.

31. Fukuyama, Thiel, and the Revenge of the Last Man

Author: Benn Steil **Published:** Oct 9, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—In the Realm of the Last Man, the title of Stanford University political scientist Francis Fukuyama's new memoir, is an unmistakable reference to his 1992 bestseller The End of History and the Last Man. The reason he chose it, Fukuyama explained, was that people had ignored his famous book's warning that "democracy could break down in the future because of some of the intrinsic stresses within a liberal order"—stresses born of the discontent of those whose desire for recognition exceeds what liberal democracy can satisfy.

32. Mélenchon Is Right About France’s Debt

Author: Yanis Varoufakis **Published:** Oct 9, 2026 **Link:** View Original

ATHENS—The sorry state of France’s public schools, which sparked angry demonstrations across the country, was a symptom of chronic austerity. But that did not stop the sirens of deeper austerity from rehearsing their song. Emmanuel Moulin, the governor of France’s central bank, is calling for large budget cuts to avert the “risk of being gradually strangled by rising interest rates.” If that happens, social tensions will be further inflamed and desperately needed investment will vanish. With Germany already confronting deindustrialization and surging support for far-right forces, France’s public debt is shaping up as Europe’s next fault line.

33. Development Finance Needs More Than One Currency

Author: Justin Yifu Lin **Published:** Oct 9, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BEIJING/BOSTON—The global development-finance gap remains large, and developing countries need more options. According to UN Trade and Development, developing countries face an annual shortfall of $4 trillion in achieving the Sustainable Development Goals. Yet for much of the postwar era, development finance has been predominantly denominated in US dollars, leaving them exposed to changes in borrowing costs and debt burdens driven by US monetary policy and investor appetite in advanced economies.

34. The French Far Right Embraces Austerity

Author: Laurent Warlouzet **Published:** Oct 9, 2026 **Link:** View Original

PARIS—Marine Le Pen, the leader of the far-right National Rally (RN) in France, has unveiled an economic program centered on rapid fiscal consolidation—more commonly known as austerity. In doing so, she has broken sharply with her own party’s past and aligned herself more closely with a longstanding trend on the European right.

35. The Journalists’ Revolt Against AI Scraping

Author: Agustino Fontevecchia **Published:** Oct 9, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BUENOS AIRES—In just a few short years, AI tools like ChatGPT and Claude have become a mainstream technology. The companies behind these innovative products tout their immense potential benefit for humanity. But this narrative, while not necessarily wrong, brushes aside that these models are built on the wholesale theft of copyrighted work and threaten to weaken further an already-fragile pillar of democracy: journalism.

36. Rating Africa on Its Own Terms

Author: Hannah Wanjie Ryder **Published:** Oct 9, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NAIROBI—Imagine taking an exam and answering every question correctly, only to fail because your paper was graded against the answer key for a different exam. That, in a nutshell, is what happens when African institutions are assessed by major credit-rating agencies like Fitch, Moody’s, and S&P.

37. A Global Economic Recovery Built on Shaky Foundations

Author: Eswar Prasad **Published:** Oct 9, 2026 **Link:** View Original

ITHACA—Despite heightened policy and geopolitical volatility, global growth has stabilized, with both advanced and emerging-market economies showing positive momentum. The October 2026 update of the Brookings-FT TIGER (Tracking Indexes for the Global Economic Recovery) reveals a world economy that, after a series of setbacks, looks set for a year of solid growth.

38. Europe Must Look Beyond the US and China to Solve Its Productivity Problem

Author: Dani Rodrik **Published:** Oct 12, 2026 **Link:** View Original

CAMBRIDGE—Europe faces a productivity crisis. Over the past quarter-century, its labor productivity has risen only half as rapidly as that of the United States, widening the gap between American and European incomes. Thanks to higher public expenditures, stronger labor-market institutions, and superior safety nets, the benefits of European economic growth are better distributed. But without improved productivity, European economies and democracies will remain at risk.

39. Can China and America Handle Being Ordinary?

Author: Nancy Qian **Published:** Oct 12, 2026 **Link:** View Original

CHICAGO—For most of the past four decades, China’s direction of travel was clear: everything was moving forward. The country’s per capita GDP was barely $300 at the start of the 1990s. But its cities would soon fill with skyscrapers, highways, and subways. Families that once worried about having enough food would buy apartments, cars, and smartphones. Children would go to universities their parents could scarcely have imagined attending. In the space of a generation, China joined the World Trade Organization, hosted the Olympics, built the world’s largest high-speed rail network, and became a central engine of the global economy.

40. Will the Bardella Scandal Sink Le Pen?

Author: Zaki Laïdi **Published:** Oct 12, 2026 **Link:** View Original

PARIS—Jordan Bardella is little known outside of France. But if Marine Le Pen, the leader of the far-right National Rally (RN), wins next spring's presidential election—as appears increasingly likely—he will, she says, be her prime minister. The question is whether the growing scandal around Bardella will cause Le Pen to change her mind and, if not, how that will affect her chances of victory.

41. A Global Debt Crisis Is Looming

Author: Paolo Gentiloni **Published:** Oct 12, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—The world is edging closer to a global debt crisis. The Iran war may have been the spark, but dry tinder has been piling up for quite a while. After a decade of debt accumulation, higher interest rates and growing refinancing needs have left the global economy increasingly exposed to shocks. And with ongoing conflicts driving up energy prices, renewed inflationary pressures are testing the limits of the existing debt architecture.

42. How to Improve Global Mineral Governance

Author: Hasrul Hanif **Published:** Oct 12, 2026 **Link:** View Original

YOGYAKARTA—Interdependence may be the theme of this year's annual meeting of the Intergovernmental Forum on Mining, Minerals, Metals, and Sustainable Development (IGF), held in Geneva on October 12–14, but competition between countries to secure transition minerals remains intense. This scramble could have dire consequences for mineral-producing countries if it undermines sustainability standards and prevents equitable cost- and benefit-sharing between and within countries.

While empirical inquiry has its place in economics, the pursuit of causality must not be allowed to displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested.

The International Energy Agency estimates that, to achieve net-zero emissions, demand for critical minerals will triple by 2030 and quadruple by 2040. Mineral-rich countries, aware of the "resource curse," are seeking ways to retain control over their reserves. In a bid to promote domestic value addition and meet their economic-development objectives, many of these countries are pursuing export bans on critical raw materials.

But Indonesia's experience as one of the first countries to implement such a ban shows that downstream industrialization is not a cure-all. It can come with substantial environmental and social costs, and the benefits are not always shared equitably with the local communities that often bear the greatest burden of extraction and processing. And while extraction, smelting, and processing have boosted economic growth in Indonesia's three nickel-rich provinces, they have not contributed significantly to the national economy. Frontier-making—the act of transforming marginal areas into centers of resource extraction—can create new "sacrifice zones" when not accompanied by robust regulation and democratic oversight.

Meanwhile, the emphasis on sustainable mining has never been greater at the global level. In 2024, the United Nations Secretary-General's Panel on Critical Energy Transition Minerals released a set of guiding principles that underscore the need for a new paradigm rooted in justice and equity, and for mining to benefit host countries and local communities. Regional frameworks, including the African Union's Africa Mining Vision, its follow-up guidelines and frameworks, and the ASEAN Principles for Sustainable Minerals Development, reflect similar commitments.

These agreements are sidelined, however, when countries pursue bilateral agreements that prioritize market access over all else. Consider the uneven treatment of nickel and palm oil in the EU–Indonesia Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement. The European Union has strict sustainability standards for palm oil, but not for nickel, even though both sectors can cause significant social and environmental degradation.

The best way to put principles into practice is to consolidate Global South policy and advocacy networks. This would enable policymakers, civil society, and local communities to share their experience with mineral extraction and processing and their proposals for making the sector more equitable and environmentally responsible.

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There is a genuine desire among policymakers in the Global South to share the lessons learned from their successes and failures. The Natural Resource Governance Institute's South–South Transition Minerals Learning Platform has facilitated the dissemination of policy insights among government officials from Indonesia, Chile, Zambia, the Democratic Republic

of the Congo, and other countries. While they share the same goal—to build more inclusive, resilient, and prosperous societies using mineral wealth—the platform enables a deeper understanding of how variations in commodities, domestic political economies, and value-chain positions require different strategies, rather than a one-size-fits-all approach.

Equally important are transnational or transcalar advocacy networks that connect civil-society groups across the Global South. They, too, can provide a platform for sharing experience and knowledge, while also strengthening collective action and extending accountability beyond national borders. By producing wide-ranging evidence of social and environmental abuses linked to mineral extraction, smelting, and processing, domestic advocacy actors can bypass governments and companies that do not adequately support local communities and directly seek out international allies to apply outside pressure.

Here, again, Indonesia provides a useful example. The prominent Indonesian NGO WALHI, together with Friends of the Earth Japan, mobilized more than one hundred organizations to urge Vale Indonesia’s shareholders to act on alleged human-rights abuses at the Sorowako nickel project. Some shareholders, including Vale, Sumitomo Metal Mining, and Mitsui & Co., responded by exerting pressure on the company when the government failed to do so effectively.

Similarly, campaigners from Mighty Earth, Climate Rights International, and Global Witness attracted investors’ attention by alleging widespread abuses in Indonesia’s nickel extraction and processing industry. They urged electric-vehicle battery and car producers to comply with social and environmental standards and due-diligence obligations. Weda Bay Nickel has since expressed interest in complying with Initiative for Responsible Mining Assurance standards, and some automakers have imposed stricter requirements on nickel suppliers.

This global pressure—which includes Publish What You Pay Indonesia raising concerns about the country’s nickel governance at the 2025 OECD Forum on Responsible Mineral Supply Chains—has forced the Indonesian government’s hand. After assessing the gap between its regulatory framework and three global standards, the government is preparing ESG (environmental, social, and governance) guidelines to help firms identify which Indonesian regulations meet the requirements of global standards in the nickel supply chain.

Advancing inclusion in transition-mineral supply chains—the goal of the IGF meeting—requires strategies for translating lofty declarations into concrete action. This can be achieved by bringing together and strengthening Global South policy and advocacy networks. Existing South–South cooperation mechanisms can expand their reach to facilitate policy learning on critical minerals, while domestic civil-society groups can deepen their global connections to put a spotlight on mining-related environmental destruction and human-rights abuses. Many pieces of the puzzle are already in place; now it is time to put them together.

43. The Rise of Reputation Ops

Author: Carla Norrlöf **Published:** Oct 13, 2026 **Link:** View Original

TORONTO—Attacks on one’s reputation used to be the price that celebrities paid for fame. But now it is a hazard of ordinary life. Anyone with any standing to lose is vulnerable. If you have an online presence, the damage can spread much further and faster than the truth. Run-of-the-mill bad publicity or harassment might dent your confidence or cause annoyance, but if you become the target of a technologically augmented campaign aimed at destroying your reputation, you could lose much more.

44. Public Investment Is Fiscally Responsible

Author: Mariana Mazzucato **Published:** Oct 13, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—Whether a hospital can hire nurses, a school can repair its roof, or a country can build a clean-energy grid often depends on factors that rarely make the news. For many governments, rules limiting deficits, debt, or spending ultimately determine whether they can invest in the future.

45. Trump’s Misguided War Against Effective Altruism

Author: Peter Singer **Published:** Oct 13, 2026 **Link:** View Original

MELBOURNE—“Americanism, not effective altruism.” That’s a new slogan launched on X by the US Department of “War,” the words running across an image of President Donald Trump saluting. Above the image, the post reads: “The United States will continue to be AI DOMINANT!”

46. Futureless Russia

Author: Nina L. Khrushcheva **Published:** Oct 13, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—On September 25, a Moscow court sent the political analyst Alexander Kynev to pretrial detention for “large-scale illegal drug production, sale, and trafficking”—a charge that could land him in prison for 10–20 years. But no evidence of Kynev’s involvement in illegal drugs has been made public.

47. A Stronger Renminbi Is No Quick Fix for Global Imbalances

Author: Kai Guo **Published:** Oct 13, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BEIJING—The renminbi is back at the center of debates about global macroeconomic imbalances. With China's merchandise trade surplus widening to $1.2 trillion in 2025, and with its manufacturing sector becoming increasingly dominant, the near-consensus among financial and economic commentators is that the renminbi is significantly undervalued. The implication is that China should let its currency appreciate sharply, thereby shrinking its surplus, easing competitive pressure on manufacturers elsewhere, and helping rebalance the global economy.

48. The Blindness of China’s All-Seeing State

Author: Yaqiu Wang **Published:** Oct 14, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—China’s surveillance state reaches into the most banal corners of life. At a garden in Yangzhou, visitors must scan their faces to receive toilet paper; the dispenser remembers them and refuses to provide a second serving. In Shenzhen, the police use facial-recognition technology to catch jaywalkers, then send penalties to scofflaws’ phones and notify their employers. The scrutiny is not limited to public spaces. For China-registered users, WeChat messages and images are automatically screened. One human-rights lawyer recalled that police monitored his WeChat exchanges before detaining and torturing him.

49. Trump’s Latest Gift to Putin

Author: Timothy Snyder **Published:** Oct 14, 2026 **Link:** View Original

TORONTO—Earlier this year, when I first described the guiding principle of Donald Trump’s foreign policy as superpower suicide, it was already obvious that the US President’s war of whimsy against Iran was a strategic catastrophe. Five months on, this failure is all the more glaring. Worse, it has provided Trump with another pretext to reward Russia. Weakness has begotten more weakness.

50. How a Pause on Frontier AI Could Work

Author: Barry Eichengreen **Published:** Oct 14, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BERKELEY—Dario Amodei, a co-founder of Anthropic, among others, has warned that AI poses an existential threat to humankind. Others have gone further and argued for pausing the training of new frontier AI models. The counterargument is that regulation, including self-regulation, is unlikely to be effective. And even if a pause is feasible in principle, there is little hope that it could be sustained in practice, given that the United States and China desperately fear falling behind each other.

51. Why Following in Milei’s Footsteps Would Be Bad for Brazil

Author: Laura Carvalho **Published:** Oct 14, 2026 **Link:** View Original

SÃO PAULO/BUENOS AIRES—Brazil’s presidential election is headed to a runoff. Flávio Bolsonaro—son of disgraced former President Jair Bolsonaro—finished ahead of the incumbent, Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, in the first round, but neither gained the majority needed to win outright.

52. China’s Panda Diplomacy Is Losing Its Charm

Author: Brahma Chellaney **Published:** Oct 14, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BERLIN—During his recent visit to Washington, Chinese President Xi Jinping announced that China would send a breeding pair of giant pandas to Zoo Atlanta. The “envoys of friendship,” Ping Ping and Fu Shuang, arrived just a few days later. This is hardly the first time China has used its iconic bear as an instrument of soft power. By loaning the animals to overseas zoos, it seeks to project an image of China not as a threatening dragon, but rather as a tough but cuddly charmer.

53. How Worried Should We Be About the Global Economy?

Author: Dambisa Moyo **Published:** Oct 14, 2026 **Link:** View Original

JAIPUR—It is difficult to remember a time when economies, financial markets, politics, and societies were subject to significant volatility and uncertainty simultaneously, let alone to the degree they are today.

54. Strict Liability for AI Executives

Author: Danielle Keats Citron **Published:** Oct 15, 2026 **Link:** View Original

CHARLOTTESVILLE—Twenty years ago, I argued that the creation of databases of sensitive information—including home addresses, biometric data, and Social Security numbers—should be understood as ultrahazardous activities. They could be managed only if the entities creating them were held fully liable for breaches. As AI models generate new and extreme risks, the need for a strict-liability regime is urgent. If frontier companies bore strict responsibility for the destruction caused by their AI chatbots and agents, they might slow down to figure out how to conduct their activities safely and change course where that is not possible.

55. Independent AI Auditing Now

Author: Angela Huyue Zhang **Published:** Oct 15, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LOS ANGELES—Hardly a week goes by without another report of an AI agent from a leading US lab digitally breaching businesses or even government services. In July, OpenAI agents escaped an internal testing environment and attacked the collaboration-platform company Hugging Face. In June, another OpenAI model gained nonpublic access to an Australian government Medicare statistics service while trying to complete a research task. And in the latest revelation, an Anthropic agent broke into the US State Department website and filled out visa applications.

56. The Institutional Roots of Policy Nonsense

Author: Jim O'Neill **Published:** Oct 15, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—Two recent conversations confirmed my suspicion that too many experts are operating in silos and often failing to connect the dots.

57. Is Christian Democracy Finished?

Author: Jan-Werner Mueller **Published:** Oct 15, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BERLIN—Recent state elections in Germany have been portrayed as momentous, since the far right finished first in two and may well come to power in one. Yet future historians may focus on another, largely overlooked outcome: For the first time in the post-World War II period, Germany’s Christian Democrats (CDU) failed to pass the 5% electoral threshold. Worse, this disastrous result occurred in the largely rural state of Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, where former Chancellor Angela Merkel chaired the CDU’s state branch for close to seven years.

58. Who Will Pay to Preserve Tropical Forests?

Author: Carlos Nobre **Published:** Oct 15, 2026 **Link:** View Original

SÃO PAULO/STIRLING—The enormous climate, water, and biodiversity benefits generated by tropical forests accrue to the entire world. But hardly any of the economic value created is captured by the countries and communities that safeguard them. The Tropical Forest Forever Facility (TFFF) was launched at last year's United Nations Climate Change Conference (COP30) in Belém to start correcting this imbalance.

While empirical inquiry has its place in economics, the pursuit of causality must not be allowed to displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested.

For too long, it has been more profitable to destroy tropical forests than to conserve them, even though they provide services essential for the survival of many countries and for the welfare of us all. The Amazon recycles nearly half of its rainfall and exports moisture that shapes precipitation patterns across South America and beyond. The Congo Basin, with its peatlands that store roughly 30 billion tons of carbon, is one of the planet's great carbon reservoirs, while many of the plant and animal species in Borneo are found nowhere else on Earth.

Moreover, across the tropics, forests support the livelihoods of hundreds of millions of people—including Indigenous communities whose stewardship is often essential for maintaining them—while also sustaining local cultures and bolstering food and water security.

But market prices do not adequately reflect these benefits, creating an economic barrier that all tropical regions bump up against: in the short term, clearing a hectare of forest can generate more income than protecting it, even when the long-term costs of forest loss are much greater. As a result, cattle ranching and agricultural expansion exert enormous pressure on the Amazon, small- and large-scale agriculture contribute to forest conversion in the Congo Basin, and industrial plantations have transformed sylvan landscapes in Southeast Asia.

Worryingly, a recent brief by the UN Sustainable Development Solutions Network emphasizes that international public finance remains far below the estimated investment required for conserving tropical forests, and that competition for declining official development aid is intensifying.

Grants and concessional loans remain indispensable for strengthening institutions, protecting rights, restoring degraded landscapes, and supporting activities with large social and ecological returns but limited commercial returns. Yet, traditional development finance alone cannot close the gap. Nor should scarce public resources be used simply to absorb risks for private investors.

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This is where the TFFF comes in. It is designed to provide eligible tropical-forest countries with predictable, long-term payments for maintaining forest cover and meeting agreed performance criteria. This changes the economic incentives: according to the TFFF's current model, countries will forgo around $400 per deforested hectare. Because each hectare of standing tropical forest increases a country's payment, policymakers may be more willing to implement robust national strategies that complement the TFFF, like Reducing Emissions from Deforestation and Forest Degradation (REDD+).

The TFFF's proposed architecture includes a commitment to direct at least 20% of payments to Indigenous Peoples and Local Communities, who play an outsize role in protecting forests but have historically received only a small share of international climate and nature finance. The real test will be whether this commitment results in predictable funding that reaches those managing forests on the ground and, in the process, reinforces local governance.

Of course, the TFFF is not a silver bullet. No single solution can close the financing gap for tropical-forest conservation. Public and private funding, domestic expenditure, concessional loans, grants, results-based payments, and new investment mechanisms must all play a role. Perhaps more importantly, no financial mechanism can compensate indefinitely for incentives that continue to encourage deforestation. To change them, policymakers must intervene.

The TFFF has a role to play here, too. To succeed, it must not only mobilize enough capital to translate global commitments into predictable payments on the ground, but also support governments in implementing policies that protect forests and complement existing forest-finance instruments. These include strengthening land rights and environmental governance, repurposing harmful subsidies, supporting restoration, and expanding viable economic opportunities compatible with standing forests.

For decades, the international community has acknowledged the extraordinary value of tropical forests while failing to invest adequately in their conservation. Ensuring that they remain standing is in everyone's interests. The challenge now is to use all tools at our disposal, not least the TFFF, to turn talk into action.

59. From AI Boom to Economic Bust

Author: Ian Goldin **Published:** Oct 16, 2026 **Link:** View Original

OXFORD—The divide between AI fantasists and doomsters is growing. The fantasists believe AI will turbocharge growth and create a utopian world of abundance. The doomsters believe it poses an existential threat to humanity and that, before killing us, it will lead to mass unemployment and a world of pervasive surveillance and alternative realities. Who is right? And can governments do anything to mitigate the risk of catastrophe?

60. Japan Needs Higher Interest Rates

Author: Koichi Hamada **Published:** Oct 16, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW HAVEN—On a recent visit to Sapporo, the city on Japan’s northern island where my parents came from, my wife and I found gentle people, mild autumn days, and excellent food. As tourists who live and work in the United States, we also enjoyed very low prices: lunch at a high-quality restaurant cost only about $20 per person. While that was convenient for us, like so many other tourists who have headed to Japan to take advantage of favorable exchange rates, the cheap yen (yen yasu) has been hard on Japan’s economy.

61. Low Expectations for Israel’s Election

Author: Shlomo Ben-Ami **Published:** Oct 16, 2026 **Link:** View Original

TEL AVIV—In Hungary’s general election in April, Prime Minister Viktor Orbán’s right-wing populist government was toppled not by some leftist opposition, but rather by a center-right party committed to fighting corruption and restoring democracy. As Israel heads to the polls on October 27, a similar shift is by far the best outcome one can reasonably hope for, with Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s extremist government replaced by a decent, law-abiding administration. A radically new foreign policy will remain out of reach.

62. A Global Euro Must First Win Over Europe

Author: Piroska Nagy Mohácsi **Published:** Oct 16, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—As the global monetary order becomes increasingly fragmented, the European Union has a rare opportunity to shape the emerging system and bolster the euro’s international role. But for the euro to become genuinely global, it must first become more European.

63. A Middle-Powers Grand Strategy to Prevent Atrocities

Author: Aarif Abraham **Published:** Oct 16, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—“Never again” to genocide is one of the international community’s most brittle postwar promises, often invoked only after the killing has begun. Yet mass atrocities seldom arrive without warning. Attacks on the rule of law, discrimination, dehumanization, and impunity for earlier crimes are familiar, easily discernible precursors.

64. Unleashing Africa’s Women Agripreneurs

Author: Ana Maria Loboguerrero **Published:** Oct 16, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—If you picture a woman working in agriculture in Africa, what image comes to mind? Maybe it’s a young woman with an infant slung on her back, hacking at the soil in searing heat, struggling to find affordable fertilizer or a decent price for her crop. Or maybe she’s a successful entrepreneur building a vibrant food business, employing hundreds of workers, and contributing much to her local economy.

While empirical inquiry has its place in economics, the pursuit of causality must not be allowed to displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested.

Both women are real, of course, as are many variations in between. But the fact is that many more women could be leading farming businesses and driving economic growth if the barriers they face were tackled more systematically. With Africa’s food and agriculture market predicted to reach around $1 trillion by 2030, countries that want to harness the most value cannot afford to forgo women’s economic power.

In Sub-Saharan Africa, over three-quarters of working women can be found in the agrifood sector, where around two-thirds of their work happens off the farm, in processing, aggregation, storage, and informal trade. Although these are the links in the chain where value is added, the women performing such roles often remain trapped in precarious, low-paid, informal arrangements.

At the other end of the spectrum is a growing cadre of dynamic African women food entrepreneurs or “agripreneurs.” I recently encountered some of these women business leaders at the Africa Food Systems Forum in Rwanda, where they were being honored for their success.

Ifeoma Mary Okonkwo, for example, co-founded a solar-powered cassava business in Nigeria that processes 15 tons per day into gluten-free flour, starch, fortified foods, and animal feed for domestic and export markets. In the space of a decade, her company has grown to employ hundreds of people. It has purchased cassava worth more than $4.45 million from its network of 2,000 (mostly women) farmers, while helping them access fertilizer, technical advice, and markets.

Okonkwo’s story shows what can happen when governments and donors make a deliberate effort to empower women-led businesses. Among other advantages, she was able to access finance on favorable terms through women-focused lending schemes.

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But much more must be done. A recent World Bank report, Women, Business, and the Law 2026, shows that legal equality on paper does not automatically produce economic opportunity. Women may have the right to register a business or open a line of credit, but their ability to formalize operations, invest, and expand is still limited by weak enforcement, a thin financial infrastructure, restrictive social norms, or unpaid care work.

Updating antiquated land ownership laws would be a good start, since inheritance customs and social norms routinely override women’s legal land rights in practice. Still, passing a law isn’t the same as enforcing it, and the same caveat applies to gender-equal business laws. In each case, implementing legal changes matters as much as enacting them.

Fortunately, when it comes to empowering rural women to move from subsistence farming to viable small businesses, a growing body of evidence shows what works. In Ethiopia, for example, agriculture employs around 80% of the country's workforce, yet female farm managers were producing at least one-third less per hectare than men—a gender gap that was costing the country more than $1 billion annually. So, the agriculture ministry, with support from the Gates Foundation, partnered with CARE, an international NGO, on a program that cuts out middlemen by connecting women's producer groups directly to markets and provides training in climate-conscious farming and nutrition.

Over the past decade, this "Farmer Field and Business School" model has expanded across multiple African countries, yielding strong results. In Burundi, for example, women's crop yields increased substantially. By pooling savings, sharing market intelligence, and lending to one another, women have been able to diversify their small farming businesses, establish credit histories, and build their confidence.

India offers a parallel example. PANI, a local organization rooted in Gandhian values, has spread climate-conscious farming knowledge and market access from woman to woman across tens of thousands of households through trained community advisers.

Underlying these and other programs is a focus on educating and upskilling women, while addressing the deep-seated gender norms that stifle their opportunities. The Ethiopian project engages men in community dialogues to challenge the norms that treat farming as a male pursuit and household chores as a female domain. The women taking part report greater confidence and decision-making power; both women and men say their partnerships are now stronger as a result.

Philanthropy can play its part by helping to scale proven approaches, by backing emerging innovations that are designed around women's needs—from climate-resilient crops and livestock to AI-powered digital tools—and by linking international financing to clear gender-equality goals.

One promising example, a climate-finance model led by the International Fund for Agricultural Development, ties funding to measurable gains in women's economic opportunities—making gender equality part of the investment itself, rather than a secondary objective. The model has already helped direct $118.5 million in investments in several countries, helping rural women gain greater control over land and productive assets, strengthen their livelihoods, and build resilience to climate change.

This last point is crucial, because it is now well established that climate change is hitting women farmers hardest, compounding deep-rooted inequalities. Research in low- and middle-income countries has found that a 1° Celsius rise in average temperatures is associated with a 34% greater reduction in income for female-headed households compared to male-headed households.

As the effects of climate change intensify, governments, development partners, and philanthropic organizations must do more to create conditions for rural women to adapt, build resilience, and prosper. Women like Okonkwo show what is possible. They are already sustaining food systems; positioning them to lead will drive the structural changes our societies need.

65. The End of Abundance

Author: V. Anantha Nageswaran **Published:** Oct 19, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW DELHI—From the early 1980s until the COVID-19 pandemic hit in 2020, the world economy enjoyed unusually good conditions. The Cold War ended, defense budgets shrank, and hundreds of millions of workers joined the global market. Energy and metals were mostly cheap, and supply chains stretched across borders on the assumption that goods would always move freely. Inflation was on a downward trend, owing partly to central banks and partly to the strong tide of peace, globalization, and plentiful supply they were swimming in.

66. The State That Remembers

Author: Christopher A. Pissarides **Published:** Oct 19, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—Just as companies refine what they know about their customers with every click, purchase, and failed transaction, government-provided services collect information about their clients, commission evaluations, and employ armies of analysts. Yet many governments cannot articulate what they believe about a given policy: what effect they expect it to produce, how confident they are, and which evidence would change their minds.

67. A Nobel for the Poor People’s Lawyer

Author: Adekeye Adebajo **Published:** Oct 19, 2026 **Link:** View Original

PRETORIA—The choice of South African jurist Navanethem “Navi” Pillay for this year’s Nobel Peace Prize was a striking show of support for the rules-based multilateral system. It was also a slap in the face to US President Donald Trump, who has shamelessly lobbied for the prize while simultaneously attacking the international legal order. At a political rally shortly after the announcement, Trump dismissed Pillay as “a liberal person who works at the United Nations, who nobody has ever heard of.”

68. MAGA at the Acropolis

Author: Loukas Tsoukalis **Published:** Oct 19, 2026 **Link:** View Original

ATHENS—On a recent visit to Athens, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio extolled ancient Greece as the foundation of Western civilization and drew inspiration for the United States today as the leader of the West. Rubio's speech at the Pnyx, a hill west of the Acropolis where democracy was first practiced, was a bold and eloquent attempt to trace MAGA's ideological roots back to Athenian democracy, as well as to Christendom, important discoveries, and imperial conquests. And it was about "us" and "them": the West and the rest.

69. Breathing New Life Into Organized Labor

Author: Jeffrey Vogt **Published:** Oct 19, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—The International Labour Organization (ILO) was established at a time when, much like today, society was riven by vast inequalities. In the years before World War I, workers' militant organizing and mass strikes alarmed employers and governments. The premise of the ILO Constitution, adopted in 1919, was that collective bargaining could prevent revolution by turning class conflict into negotiated, shared gains.

While empirical inquiry has its place in economics, the pursuit of causality must not be allowed to displace the pursuit of explanation. Beyond identifying causal effects within existing arrangements, economists must investigate how those arrangements are produced, reproduced, and contested.

This arrangement assumed that an international floor for labor standards would halt a race to the bottom on wages and working conditions as countries compete for trade and investment. For roughly three decades after World War II, that assumption generally held up, benefiting millions of workers, though mostly in formal employment in the industrialized Global North.

It is no longer the case today. The UN's 2026 Sustainable Development Goals Annual Report notes that the weakening of labor rights worldwide is "leaving many increasingly constrained or unable to organize or bargain collectively." According to the International Trade Union Confederation's Global Rights Index, 80% of the 121 countries surveyed restricted collective bargaining in 2026, and 87% restricted the right to strike. The OECD also reports that union density has been falling in its member economies for decades. In many countries, capital is more concentrated, and governments are more captured by it, than at any time in the last century.

The unraveling of the 1919 compromise was not an accident. The relationship between firm and worker, and the corresponding obligations, were intentionally severed through vertical disintegration across global supply chains, subcontracting, and labor intermediation. Digital-platform work, the most recent manifestation of this, relies on widespread employment misclassification that denies millions of workers their legal rights.

Although global value chains have been a reality of manufacturing and services for decades, not enough progress has been made on negotiating global rules to protect workers' rights and hold lead firms accountable. Employers' opposition to standard-setting on this issue at the ILO remains deeply entrenched. They insist that, instead of regulating their practices, we should focus on getting results from labor inspectorates—government agencies that are usually underfunded and disempowered—at the site of manufacture or service provision.

Many countries no longer have the capacity or the incentive to legislate a global rights floor, owing to economic liberalization and capital mobility. At the same time, investors have acquired and used provisions of trade and investment agreements to sue governments directly over laws and policies that might affect their profitability. Moreover, governments put other priorities ahead of enforcing laws that would help raise living standards. Even the novel "rapid response labor mechanism" under the United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement, designed to promote freedom of association and collective bargaining at the firm level, is faltering for lack of political will.

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Addressing these problems will require more than another declaration. Organized workers and the fear of revolution produced the bargain of 1919. The ILO Constitution merely ratified what worker power had already achieved. Its premise

remains valid—and a robust global labor architecture is still necessary—but the assumption that compromise was somehow self-executing was always mistaken. Instead, workers' organizations have been steadily undermined by regressive legislation and a multi-billion-dollar industry that supports employers' "union avoidance" efforts.

Fulfilling the ILO's promise requires a concerted global effort to create an enabling environment for all workers and their organizations to organize and bargain collectively, at home, across borders, and down supply chains, where decision-makers are located. Countervailing power must be rebuilt, including by ensuring that labor can operate across borders as easily as capital does. That means institutionalizing transnational collective bargaining, as well as sectoral bargaining and extension mechanisms (which spread union contracts to other workers). Solidarity action needs to be protected, or else the right to strike can do little good when decision-makers are located elsewhere. And vulnerable workers—including the two billion informal workers, digital-platform workers, and dependent self-employed workers—require an effective right to organize and bargain.

Labor rights must be an effective feature of international economic governance as well. While the ILO supervisory system may have persuasive remedies, they need legal regimes to give them effect. Compliance will never be mandated in Geneva. It must be enforced through constitutional litigation, regional human-rights courts, trade agreements, and procurement and financial regulations. That could mean rapid, trade-linked remedies against companies that violate workers' fundamental rights, and enforceable supply-chain agreements between workers, brands, and suppliers.

With the world poised to overshoot the Paris climate agreement's target of limiting global warming to 1.5° Celsius, these reforms have become essential. The climate crisis is also a crisis of workers' rights, and addressing one can address the other. Global warming is already affecting workers, whether through job displacement in carbon-intensive industries or through extreme heat, crop failure, coastal erosion, and other disasters. While workers and trade unions are widely recognized as indispensable actors in any just climate transition, the legal infrastructure needed to ensure that they have a voice in shaping that transition is underdeveloped or non-existent in many countries.

Finally, the expansion of AI, automated management, and digital surveillance is rapidly transforming work, threatening jobs and fundamental rights, and further exacerbating inequality, from warehouses to digital labor platforms.

Where workers' organizations once could bargain effectively, now authoritarian oligarchs largely control the levers of power. That need not be the case. We can reverse this lopsided dynamic, but only if workers can lawfully organize and act on the same scale as capital. Addressing the challenges of our time depends on it.

70. The Algorithm Driving French Student Protests

Author: Gabriela Ramos **Published:** Oct 20, 2026 **Link:** View Original

PARIS—Hundreds of thousands of young people have taken to the streets in France to protest against the state of the country’s education system. The violence that erupted on October 17 should not eclipse their concerns, which are entirely legitimate: the deplorable conditions at many French schools, including dilapidated buildings, a lack of teachers, overcrowded classrooms, and long school days. They are also deeply opposed to Parcoursup, the country’s university-admissions platform, which has become the lightning rod for their grievances. They have denounced it as opaque, stressful, and unfair.

71. Brazil Cannot Afford Bolsonaro’s Spending Cuts

Author: Laura Carvalho **Published:** Oct 20, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—Brazil faces a stark choice on October 25, when far-right candidate Flávio Bolsonaro and President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva face off in the country’s presidential runoff.

72. A Generational Reckoning on the Streets of Paris

Author: Jonathan Levy **Published:** Oct 20, 2026 **Link:** View Original

PARIS—After weeks of mounting tension on the streets of Paris, my wife and I decided to take our six-year-old daughter and leave town during Saturday’s protests. When the main demonstration assembled at 2 p.m. at the Place de la République, we were hiking in the forests southeast of Paris near Fontainebleau, once an autumnal retreat and hunting ground for French kings.

73. Mexico Faces the Populist Tide

Author: Guillermo Ortiz **Published:** Oct 20, 2026 **Link:** View Original

MEXICO CITY—Latin America’s political map has been redrawn with remarkable speed. Since April 2025, center- or far-right forces have won power in Bolivia, Chile, Colombia, Costa Rica, Ecuador, Honduras, and Peru. In Argentina, President Javier Milei’s populist party secured a decisive victory in midterm elections last October. And in Brazil, the right-wing Senator Flávio Bolsonaro finished ahead of President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva in the first round of the recent presidential election 47% to 45%.

74. When Smart Cities Turn Menacing

Author: Wairagala Wakabi **Published:** Oct 21, 2026 **Link:** View Original

KAMPALA—In June 2025, Uganda switched on the Automated Express Penalty System (EPSAuto), using CCTV cameras, automatic number plate recognition (ANPR), and an intelligent transport monitoring system (ITMS) to fine motorists. But the system, ostensibly aimed at bringing order to the country’s chaotic roads, quickly generated controversy.

75. Science Without Scientists?

Author: Sami Mahroum **Published:** Oct 21, 2026 **Link:** View Original

PARIS—Given current AI capabilities, does it matter who conducts scientific research? The intuitive response is that a fact is a fact, regardless of who finds it. But knowledge is never disseminated that way. We receive most scientific claims without any means of checking them ourselves, so we tend to judge not the claim but the credibility of whoever stands behind it. As the Harvard historian of science Steven Shapinshows, the production of scientific truth has long been inseparable from the social work of persuading one’s peers.

76. What’s Driving Persistent Inflation?

Author: Şebnem Kalemli-Özcan **Published:** Oct 21, 2026 **Link:** View Original

PROVIDENCE—It was only a few months ago that investors were preoccupied with US tariffs and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz. But these issues have since receded from the forefront of our concerns, overshadowed by anxiety over the AI boom and possible bust, rising bond yields, and mounting public debt.

77. Which AI Myth Will We Embrace?

Author: Richard K. Sherwin **Published:** Oct 21, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW YORK—It is telling that Anthropic chose to call its most powerful AI model “Mythos.” In ancient Greek, the word denotes an original reality that we can imitate or embody through the stories we tell ourselves and one another. Pliny the Elder tells us that the fifth-century Greek painter Zeuxis rendered grapes so realistically as to fool even the birds.

78. No More Superpowers

Author: Carl Bildt **Published:** Oct 21, 2026 **Link:** View Original

STOCKHOLM—As the term “middle powers” has gained currency this year, it has forced us to ask which countries actually belong to this grouping. After all, shouldn’t most states be described that way?

79. Building the Economy Africa Needs

Author: Yemi Kale **Published:** Oct 21, 2026 **Link:** View Original

ABUJA—As geopolitical tensions reshape the world economy, Africa faces a choice: it can allow itself to be carried along by events into an uncertain future, or it can use the ongoing shifts in the international order as an opening to position itself as a more influential global player.

80. A Competitive Europe Must Be Climate-Resilient

Author: Ambroise Fayolle **Published:** Oct 22, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LUXEMBOURG—There is no choice between investing in resilience and investing in competitiveness. They are increasingly one and the same. Climate risk has become economic risk and a matter of economic security.

81. Argentina’s Economic Chainsaw Massacre

Author: Jeremy Adelman **Published:** Oct 22, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BUENOS AIRES—Nearly three years after Javier Milei became Argentina’s president, the chainsaw-wielding free-marketeer has established himself as the darling of the far right. Brazil’s right-wing presidential candidate, Flávio Bolsonaro, is promising an economic policy that would follow Milei’s lead, and US President Donald Trump calls him his “favorite president.” Last year, Trump extended Argentina an unprecedented $20 billion currency swap line to halt its currency’s free fall on the eve of legislative elections, and the gambit worked. Milei’s party won a surprising victory.

82. Europe Must Prepare for the Worst

Author: Janis A. Emmanouilidis **Published:** Oct 22, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BRUSSELS—What if the greatest threat to the European Union is not Russian aggression, Chinese exports, or US President Donald Trump, but actually comes from within the bloc?

83. Nature Can’t Wait

Author: Mary Robinson **Published:** Oct 22, 2026 **Link:** View Original

YEREVAN—In times of war, geopolitical turmoil, and fiscal tightening, it is tempting to view the defense of nature as a desirable but non-urgent goal—an objective that can be pursued when calmer times return. But we embrace this view at our peril.

For generations, countries have escaped poverty by putting millions of people to work in factories and service industries. But as robots replace factory workers and AI takes over service jobs, the growth engines that have powered economic development across much of the world will be rendered obsolete.

As world leaders gather for the United Nations biodiversity and climate-change conferences this fall, they must remember that over half of global GDP depends on nature and the services it provides. Healthy soils underpin a $9.5 trillion global food industry, while forests support 1.5 billion livelihoods around the world. Healthy rivers help absorb floodwaters and sustain vital transportation networks. Nature is the backbone of the global economy, and protecting it must be a top national and international priority.

Nature-related crises won’t wait until the wars in the Middle East and Ukraine are over. This summer’s sweltering drought in Europe caused $2-3 billion in crop losses, a double blow for farmers after the war-induced closure of the Strait of Hormuz caused fertilizer prices to surge by 71%. The combined effects of conflict and extreme weather have helped push global food prices to their highest levels since 2022.

All told, scientists predict that a partial collapse of ecosystems could cost the global economy $2.7 trillion annually. Despite intense geopolitical instability, we cannot afford to undermine the natural systems on which our economies depend. The global goal to protect and conserve at least 30% of the world’s land and ocean by 2030, known as 30x30, is more important than ever.

Protecting nature is an investment in resilience and solidarity. Resilience strengthens food and water security, and the capacity to weather climate shocks. It sustains livelihoods, public health, and long-term economic stability. The 30x30 goal, adopted by governments in 2022 under the landmark Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework, recognizes that protecting nature is fundamental to providing these and other public goods.

For example, kelp beds, mangroves, and marshes absorb carbon dioxide, while coral reefs help protect against storms and provide natural habitats for some of the world’s most diverse ecosystems. On land, forests regulate rainfall and support the livelihoods of local communities, and healthy soils retain water and nutrients that are vital to global food security and flood protection.

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Four years on, the world has made significant strides toward the 30x30 goal. New analysis from Campaign for Nature shows that 20% of land and inland waters are now designated as protected or conserved, and that fully delivering on existing commitments could increase this share to approximately 27% by 2030, closing much of the remaining gap.

Progress at sea, however, has been much slower. Only 10% of the ocean is formally designated for conservation, and existing commitments would increase this to a mere 12% by 2030. Worse, Together for the Ocean’s latest Ocean

Protection Gap Report finds that only 3.5% of the ocean is assessed as effectively protected, with harmful activities continuing in many areas that are supposed to be off limits.

With just four years remaining, the world still has a chance to achieve 30x30, which is one of the defining global commitments of this decade. But what will it take to make up for lost time?

For starters, governments must dramatically increase financing for nature. Delivering 30x30 will require approximately $100–180 billion annually, compared with current annual spending of $24 billion. But, again, this spending represents an investment, not just a cost. Achieving 30x30 could add up to $450 billion to annual global GDP by 2050 and support an estimated 4–7 million jobs.

Policymakers at all levels urgently must move from talking about solutions to implementing them. As of May 2026, 116 countries had submitted commitments to protect up to 27% of land and inland water areas. But many have yet to follow up with mapped, costed, and financed plans. Commitments alone will not protect nature.

Protecting more of the planet is only part of the challenge. Governments also must ensure that protected and conserved areas are well managed, deliver real benefits, and meaningfully preserve biodiversity. That requires long-term funding arrangements that can endure through changing economic and political cycles.

There is no denying that the global outlook is uncertain. The wars in the Middle East and Ukraine are spurring governments to increase spending on defense and focus more on economic growth. But it would be a mistake to put nature on the back burner. Protecting natural systems is not just for the bees. Investing in their future is an investment in our own.

84. The Agentic Information Economy

Author: Shuwei Fang **Published:** Oct 23, 2026 **Link:** View Original

CAMBRIDGE—Information is undergoing a category change. It has always been something people consume, but it is also becoming something machines act on. That means errors will stop being mere digital impressions and start becoming actions with far-reaching consequences. Given the risks, the system will need safeguards of its own. Better data or putting a human back in the loop will not suffice.

85. How to Help Left-Behind Regions

Author: Keun Lee **Published:** Oct 23, 2026 **Link:** View Original

SEOUL—Discussion of economic inequality usually focuses on disparities across countries or the divide between rich and poor households within them. But greater attention is now being devoted to domestic regional differences, whether between the capital city and the rest of the country (as in South Korea and the United Kingdom), between northern and southern regions (as in Italy), or between coastal cities and inland areas (as in China and the United States).

86. Is a Chinese Implosion Looming?

Author: Navneeraj Sharma **Published:** Oct 23, 2026 **Link:** View Original

NEW DELHI—This has been an era of shocks. In the space of two decades, the world has witnessed globally disruptive wars—from Iraq in the 2000s to Ukraine and Iran today—a global financial crisis, a global pandemic, and a rogue American president upending the global order. Now, yet another potential shock must be addressed: Though few dare to speculate about it publicly, an economic and political perfect storm is bearing down on China.

87. Who Pays the Fiscal Watchdogs?

Author: Janet Zhou **Published:** Oct 23, 2026 **Link:** View Original

HARARE—In 2021, Zimbabwean Finance Minister Mthuli Ncube caused an uproar when he issued more than $15 million in guarantees for private loans made by the Commercial Bank of Zimbabwe without seeking parliament's approval. It was a particularly flagrant example of an unfortunately common practice in Zimbabwe: committing state resources to non-essential projects that offer no public benefit. Some of these loans invariably went unpaid, leaving taxpayers to cover the losses.

For generations, countries have escaped poverty by putting millions of people to work in factories and service industries. But as robots replace factory workers and AI takes over service jobs, the growth engines that have powered economic development across much of the world will be rendered obsolete.

In April 2022, the Zimbabwe Coalition on Debt and Development (which I led at the time), together with three co-applicants, petitioned the High Court of Zimbabwe to declare that parliament must approve public borrowing before it happens. In March 2023, the Court ordered the government to gazette a bill in the next 12 months outlining parliament's role in approving loans and guarantees and establishing the procedure for ratification or rejection.

This win was possible only because of a grant. The Open Society Initiative for Southern Africa, a regional foundation, funded the external lawyers who argued it, as well as our researchers, on a three-year cycle. When the cycle ended, the capacity to fight these legal battles went with it.

This model of financing public accountability in developing countries through grants has started to collapse. Aid from OECD donors fell by 23.1% in real terms in 2025, the largest annual drop ever recorded. Meanwhile, governments are tightening the requirements for registering civil-society organizations and limiting which of these groups can receive funding from abroad. Zimbabwe's Private Voluntary Organisations Amendment Act, enacted in April 2025, allows the authorities to cancel the registration of civil-society organizations and seize their assets without judicial oversight. El Salvador's Foreign Agents Law, passed just one month later, imposed a 30% tax on all foreign funding.

The weakening of civil-society participation will be felt widely, not least because every proposal for making global finance more sustainable and equitable depends on citizens who can read a debt-sustainability analysis and force a minister to answer for it. The Sevilla Commitment, adopted at last year's Fourth International Conference on Financing for Development, calls for strengthening parliamentary oversight of debt, independent audit institutions, and civil society's role in exposing illicit financial flows. But nobody has said who pays for that work.

The answer may lie in two types of international instruments: agreements for stolen-asset recovery and sovereign-debt treatments. Each could contain a clause mandating that a fixed share of the sum—5% is a justifiable starting point—goes toward funding independent oversight of public finance in the recipient country. The money would be protected from executive interference, publicly audited, and guaranteed for the life of the program.

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This has already been done in agreements for asset returns. In December 2017, Switzerland repatriated roughly $321 million stolen by former Nigerian President Sani Abacha under an agreement that provided for World Bank monitoring and civil-society oversight of how the money was spent. That same year, the United Kingdom, the United States, and four

focus countries—Nigeria, Sri Lanka, Tunisia, and Ukraine—adopted the GFAR (Global Forum on Asset Recovery) principles, which commit governments that are returning or receiving assets to transparency and accountability.

But, to date, such monitoring has been treated as a courtesy, extended at the discretion of the government that happens to be holding the stolen funds. The Sevilla Commitment calls for piloting new approaches to asset return, including a clause in these agreements stipulating that a third party monitors the disbursement of money for oversight to prevent tampering from the recipient government.

Debt treatments, negotiated in creditor committees and multilateral fora, could adopt a similar approach: channel a fixed share of debt-service savings to an independently governed fund that supports public-finance oversight. Grants would be awarded competitively, published in a database, and externally audited against criteria written into the settlement.

Creditors have already accepted similar terms for different categories. In 1998, Uganda ring-fenced its debt-relief savings under the Heavily Indebted Poor Countries Initiative, earmarking them for anti-poverty programs. In 2023, Ecuador completed a debt-for-nature swap in which part of the interest on the new loan pays roughly $12 million annually, for 18.5 years, into a fund for maintaining the Galápagos Islands, governed by a board of representatives from government, academia, and business.

A borrowing government will never volunteer to fund the people who audit it. But when the obligation is written into these settlements, the money survives the next budget or election. It also gives creditors insight into the borrower’s disclosure practices.

Oversight is the cheapest insurance in sovereign finance. A group of economists tracking revelations of undisclosed debt across 154 countries over the past century found that nearly half of all sovereign defaults coincided with substantial upward revisions to reported public debt. Hidden debt piles up in good times and surfaces in bad times, when someone finally examines the books. If public oversight is properly funded, outside scrutiny begins long before a default and can pave the way for reform.

Consider the order that we won from Zimbabwe’s High Court. It was an important outcome that nonetheless failed to dent the problem. A bill was drafted but not gazetted; the Court’s deadline passed with no action. The organizations that could have fought in the courts for its enforcement had moved on to other grant-funded work.

As efforts to revamp the global financial architecture accelerate, policymakers must recognize that improving debt management starts with accountability at home. At the International Monetary Fund-World Bank Annual Meetings in October, the new Borrowers’ Platform, which seeks to give developing countries a stronger voice in global debt discussions, held its first Governing Council. While proactive coordination between finance ministers and central-bank governors, as the officials who sign the loans, is essential to achieve sustainable debt levels, it must be coupled with long-term external funding for civil-society groups that can hold them to their word.

88. Lula Killed the Donroe Doctrine

Author: Jeremy Adelman **Published:** Oct 26, 2026 **Link:** View Original

RIO DE JANEIRO—Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva's victory in Brazil's presidential election is a blow to Donald Trump's plan for the Western Hemisphere. The US president was hoping to huddle with client states to the south who mimic his business and mano dura (iron fist) posturing, while further betraying liberal partners. That plan, within reach until Sunday's vote, is now in tatters.

89. The Specter of an AI-Driven Slowdown

Author: Dambisa Moyo **Published:** Oct 26, 2026 **Link:** View Original

ISTANBUL—Today’s economic growth depends heavily on AI investment and fiscal spending. The International Monetary Fund estimates that AI could add up to half a percentage point to annual global growth over the next decade, raising the average rate from 3% to 3.5%.

90. Public Control for a Purposeful Economy

Author: Mariana Mazzucato **Published:** Oct 26, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—Governments around the world say they have no room to act. Although inequality and the cost of living are rising, fiscal space, we are told, is tight. Yet in many cases, the squeeze is self-imposed. It follows from equating fiscal responsibility with cutting deficits and debt, rather than with building an economy’s capacity to grow, withstand shocks, and meet its obligations over time. In fact, cutting spending in a weak economy can leave the debt-to-GDP ratio higher, not lower; and when fiscal rules bite, public investment is often the first thing cut.

91. The Wrong Way to Compare Economic Size

Author: Jeffrey Frankel **Published:** Oct 26, 2026 **Link:** View Original

CAMBRIDGE—Last month, the Nobel laureate economist Paul Krugman gave a talk at the European Central Bank's annual research conference, which focused on geoeconomics. The term refers to countries' ability to exploit economic interactions for geopolitical ends. Think of China's threats to cut off trading partners from its exports of rare-earth minerals.

92. Rethinking Sustainable Livelihoods From the Ground Up

Author: Grita Anindarini **Published:** Oct 26, 2026 **Link:** View Original

JAKARTA—When the energy transition confronts difficult economic conditions within a country, addressing the transition's unequal impact becomes both more challenging and more imperative. In Indonesia, with an economy recently described as a "ticking time bomb," coal mining has long been the main driver of GDP in certain regencies and provinces. Pursuit of the energy transition in such places raises the tricky political question of how to support economic diversification, and boost economic growth, in these areas while also combating climate change.

The answer may seem obvious: reducing vulnerability to economic shocks caused by the shift away from fossil fuels requires broadening income sources. But that is easier said than done. A just energy transition requires a wider transformation that includes creating meaningful job opportunities, closing human-capital gaps, and alleviating poverty. Most importantly, these efforts must be highly localized to account for each area's unique strengths and each community's specific needs.

Pulau Panggung, a village located in Muara Enim, one of Indonesia's most coal-dependent regencies, in South Sumatra province, illustrates this vulnerability starkly. According to research by WALHI Sumatera Selatan (Friends of the Earth South Sumatera) and the Indonesian Center for Environmental Law, 56.7% of the village's residents are employed as mine workers, including casual laborers. When coal mining arrived in the early 1990s, the community largely abandoned farming, its main economic engine at the time. Now, as mining firms face expiring contracts and begin implementing efficiency measures, villagers' livelihoods are under threat, but this time without a ready-made substitute.

The village's post-coal economy could return to agriculture and embrace nature-based tourism. But shifting to these sectors requires a healthy ecosystem, making it essential to force companies to fulfill their obligations to restore mined land. Moreover, because villagers gave up farming decades ago, they would need training in sustainable agriculture techniques and opportunities to develop skills for other alternative livelihoods, such as digital-based marketing.

Some of the barriers to creating new livelihoods in Pulau Panggung are structural, such as the ambiguous legal status of land, a long-standing problem across Indonesia. But the bigger challenge, both here and elsewhere, is the lack of formal channels for developing effective local initiatives. Each village's strengths must serve as the foundation for community-based economic transformation. Unfortunately, Indonesia's top-down policymaking and regulatory regime, particularly in the energy sector, hinders efforts to maximize local strengths.

The Indonesian government directs transition planning by providing general guidance, which provincial and regency plans should theoretically elaborate on, identifying what is unique to each place. Yet the 2025–2029 South Sumatra medium-term regional development plan gives no clear direction on how economic transformation will be carried out, only that efforts to move away from a coal-based economy remain suboptimal. The plan recognizes that natural resources must play a role but does not explain how to use them in a way that fits the needs of each village and avoids harming ecosystems.

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This problem is not unique to Indonesia. Many other governments have similar gaps in their energy-transition policies. The key is for policymakers to enable a more bottom-up approach by focusing on two objectives.

First, policymakers must directly involve affected communities. Entrusting transition planning to local governments and giving communities a genuine role in the decision-making process would help officials and companies design tailored interventions that expand employment opportunities for workers at risk of displacement.

Embedding community-driven initiatives in these policies must begin with local assessments. Before any plan is approved, the government should conduct participatory mapping of livelihoods, land status, workforce skills, and local strengths. In Pulau Panggung, this kind of mapping would highlight its agricultural and tourism potential.

Second, policymakers should explore the possibility of a regional fund that could redirect government revenue derived from mining and fossil-fuel production toward supporting community-based transitions. One model to follow is the Alaska Permanent Fund, whereby the state government invests a portion of its oil and mining revenues for the long-term benefit of all current and future Alaskans.

Managed by a state-owned corporation, this sovereign wealth fund helps finance public services like education, health care, and basic infrastructure. Policymakers, in both developed and developing countries alike, can use such a vehicle to ensure a sustainable economic transition by operating transparently and allowing local communities to direct the proceeds toward their chosen priorities.

Time is running out to establish regional endowment funds. Policymakers in Indonesia and other countries must act before mining and fossil-fuel revenues stop flowing. As a first step, they can run pilots in affected regions—like Muara Enim—to show what is possible. Waiting too long risks leaving these communities with a plan but no capital to implement it.

93. Brazil’s Chapter in the Anti-Authoritarian Playbook

Author: Robert Muggah **Published:** Oct 27, 2026 **Link:** View Original

SÃO PAOLO—Until President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva staged a remarkable comeback to win re-election, no Brazilian presidential candidate had overturned a first-round defeat in a runoff. Lula did so with nearly 52% of the vote, against Flávio Bolsonaro’s 48%. More than 128 million Brazilians turned out—nearly three million more than in the first round.

94. Another Crash Landing for Brazil’s Economy?

Author: Gene Frieda **Published:** Oct 27, 2026 **Link:** View Original

LONDON—Brazil has an unfortunate habit of disappointing. Despite the country’s exceptional natural-resource endowment, its growth trajectory resembles what Brazilians call the flight of a chicken (voo de galinha): a brief flutter followed by an inevitable fall back down to Earth. President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva’s surprise re-election raises the risk of another letdown.

95. Europe’s Make-or-Break Moment Has Arrived

Author: Joschka Fischer **Published:** Oct 27, 2026 **Link:** View Original

BERLIN—On February 24, 2027, it will have been five years since Russia launched its full-scale invasion of Ukraine, in flagrant violation of international law. Russian President Vladimir Putin’s neo-imperialist adventure—his “special military operation”—was supposed to be a brief and decisive war of conquest. But it soon became apparent that he had underestimated his victim. The Ukrainians have been determined to defend themselves, whatever it takes, and for a while, they could count on a united West, with the United States and Europe standing together in providing military and civilian support.

96. Middle Powers Can Lead on AI Safety

Author: Gordon LaForge **Published:** Oct 27, 2026 **Link:** View Original

WASHINGTON, DC—The warnings about the safety of frontier AI models continue to grow louder. Writing in Time in early October, the former chief scientist of the United Kingdom's AI Security Institute put the probability of us all dying because of smarter-than-human AI systems at 50%. On the same day, a senior OpenAI employee announced that he had left the company because of its "broken" safety culture. But the United States has shown no interest in regulating the technology, except for a "morally binding" voluntary accord recently signed by tech CEOs and US President Donald Trump.